BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

Graduation Party Planning Kit

An open-house style graduation party, planned around the May and June Chicago crunch

Graduation season is short and everyone books at once. This kit walks you from the first venue call to the last thank-you note, with food amounts, a photo table plan, a budget split, and a rain plan so the day stays about the graduate.

INSIDE

1. Planning Timeline
2. Planning Checklists
3. Food Amounts by Guest Count
4. Budget Split
5. Display and Photo Table Plan
6. Rain and Weather Plan
7. Questions to Ask Vendors
8. Party Worksheet



beyondchiavari.com
Chairs, tables, linens, tents and more across Chicagoland, on one quote.

PART 1

Planning Timeline

Chicago-area graduation weekends fill up early. Start before the school year ends.

3 to 4 months out

- [ ] Pick two or three possible dates and check them against the school ceremony, relatives' travel, and other grads in your circle.
- [ ] Choose open-house hours, such as 1 to 5 pm, so guests can drop in without a formal meal.
- [ ] Set a total budget and decide who is contributing.
- [ ] Reserve a backyard, park shelter, banquet room, or community space and ask what rentals are included.
- [ ] Request a quote for a tent, tables, and chairs now, since May and June weekends go first.
- [ ] Book the caterer, food truck, or taco bar vendor before their calendar fills.

8 to 10 weeks out

- [ ] Draft the guest list with a first, second, and maybe-if-room tier.
- [ ] Order or design invitations and announcements.
- [ ] Pick a color scheme tied to school colors or the graduate's plans.
- [ ] Ask the graduate to pick the music, the cake flavor, and one thing they definitely want.
- [ ] Ask a friend or relative to collect photos for the display.

4 to 6 weeks out

- [ ] Mail invitations with an RSVP date about two weeks before the party.
- [ ] Confirm rental quantities for chairs, tables, linens, and any tent.
- [ ] Order the cake or dessert table items.
- [ ] Check local park or village rules on tents, amplified music, and street parking.
- [ ] Plan a photo display and order any prints, banners, or yard signs.
- [ ] Line up helpers for setup, serving, and cleanup.

2 weeks out

- [ ] Follow up with guests who have not replied.
- [ ] Give the caterer or grocery store an estimated headcount.
- [ ] Buy drinks, ice, paper goods, and serving utensils if self-catering.
- [ ] Confirm the rental delivery window and who will be home to receive it.
- [ ] Test the speaker, slideshow, or playlist.

The week of

- [ ] Check the forecast every day and decide your rain plan by Wednesday.
- [ ] Give final headcount to the caterer 7 to 10 days out if they ask for it.
- [ ] Mow, weed, and clear the yard or tidy the venue entry.
- [ ] Prepare a cooler plan: ice, extra coolers, and a spot out of the sun.
- [ ] Print a simple schedule and a map or parking note for guests.
- [ ] Pack a day-of kit with tape, scissors, trash bags, wipes, and extension cords.

Day of and after

- [ ] Set up tables and chairs at least 2 hours before guests arrive.
- [ ] Put food out in small batches to keep it fresh.
- [ ] Greet guests and make sure the graduate gets a few moments with everyone.
- [ ] Bag trash and recycling as you go.
- [ ] Stack and ready rentals for pickup per your agreement.
- [ ] Send thank-you notes within two weeks and note any gift tracking.

PART 2

Planning Checklists

Check items off as you go.

VENUE AND SPACE

- [ ] Decide indoor, outdoor, or both.
- [ ] Estimate how many guests will be there at once (usually fewer than the full list).
- [ ] Confirm access time for setup and the hard stop for cleanup.
- [ ] Check restroom access and capacity.
- [ ] Ask about parking, street permits, and neighbor notice.
- [ ] Plan a shaded or covered area for food and older guests.

RENTALS

- [ ] Seating for about 50 to 60 percent of guests at one time.
- [ ] Cocktail or standing tables for mingling.
- [ ] Banquet or six-foot tables for food, drinks, and desserts.
- [ ] A separate table for gifts and cards, with a card box.
- [ ] Tablecloths or linens in the party colors.
- [ ] Tent or canopy sized for the food area plus seating.
- [ ] Chafing dishes or warming equipment if serving hot food.
- [ ] Plates, napkins, cutlery, and cups or glassware if not using disposables.

FOOD AND DRINK

- [ ] Choose a service style: buffet, stations, food truck, or drop-off trays.
- [ ] Plan for dietary needs such as vegetarian, gluten-free, and nut allergies.
- [ ] Order a cake or cupcakes and a small cutting cake if desired.
- [ ] Plan nonalcoholic drinks first, then decide on beer or wine.
- [ ] Arrange extra ice and coolers.
- [ ] Label food with simple cards.

DISPLAY AND DECOR

- [ ] Photo timeline from baby photos to senior year.
- [ ] Trophies, jerseys, art, and awards the graduate wants to show.
- [ ] Cap and gown on a stand or in a clear display area.
- [ ] A guest book or advice cards for the graduate.
- [ ] Balloons, banner, and yard signs.
- [ ] A memory jar or video recording station for guests.

DAY OF

- [ ] Assign someone to manage the cooler and drinks.
- [ ] Assign a photographer or photo-taker for candid shots.
- [ ] Put out hand sanitizer and a trash station.
- [ ] Have a rain plan helper ready to move signs, tables, and food.
- [ ] Collect gifts and cards in one secure spot.
- [ ] Send leftovers home with relatives in disposable containers.

PART 3

Food Amounts by Guest Count

Rough guidelines for a 3 to 4 hour open house. Adjust for the time of day and your crowd.

Item	25 guests	50 guests	75 guests	100 guests
Main dishes (sandwiches, tacos, pasta, etc.)	30 to 40 portions	60 to 80 portions	90 to 120 portions	120 to 160 portions
Side salad or slaw	3 to 4 quarts	6 to 8 quarts	9 to 12 quarts	12 to 16 quarts
Chips and snacks	3 lbs	6 lbs	9 lbs	12 lbs
Dips and veggie tray	1 large tray	2 large trays	3 large trays	4 large trays
Sheet cake plus extras	1 quarter sheet plus 12 cupcakes	1 half sheet plus 24 cupcakes	1 full sheet	1 full sheet plus 24 cupcakes
Cold drinks (cans and bottles)	50 to 75	100 to 150	150 to 225	200 to 300
Water	1 case plus a jug	2 cases plus jugs	3 cases plus jugs	4 cases plus jugs
Ice	20 lbs	40 lbs	60 lbs	80 lbs
Plates, napkins, cups	50 each	100 each	150 each	200 each
Chairs	15 to 20	30 to 40	45 to 60	60 to 80
Tables (food, gifts, seating, cocktail)	3 to 4	6 to 8	9 to 12	12 to 16

PART 4

Budget Split

Typical shares of a graduation party budget. Use this as a starting point and adjust.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Food and catering	40%	$_____	Open houses run lighter than a dinner, so consider grazing tables and a few quality hot items.
Drinks and ice	10%	$_____	Water, lemonade, and soda go further than you expect.
Rentals (tables, chairs, tent, linens)	20%	$_____	Get quotes early. Tent prices in May and June are higher because demand is high.
Venue or space fees	8%	$_____	Park shelters and community rooms are often the least expensive.
Cake and desserts	6%	$_____	A cutting cake plus cupcakes can lower cost.
Decor, photos, and signs	8%	$_____	A printed photo timeline is a simple, personal centerpiece.

Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Invitations and postage	4%	$_____	Digital invitations save money and are easy to update.
Music and entertainment	2%	$_____	A speaker and playlist is often enough.
Contingency	2%	$_____	Keep a small cushion for last-minute needs like extra ice.

PART 5

Display and Photo Table Plan

A good display gives guests something to talk about.

PHOTOS

- [ ] Gather 20 to 40 photos spanning toddler through senior year.
- [ ] Scan old prints at 300 dpi or take clear photos of them.
- [ ] Print at 4x6 or 5x7 and group them by era.
- [ ] Use clips on twine, a corkboard, or foam board so nothing gets damaged.
- [ ] Add short captions with ages or grades.

MEMORABILIA

- [ ] Pick three to five meaningful items instead of everything.
- [ ] Include team photos, awards, and favorite projects.
- [ ] Display the diploma cover or a framed program.
- [ ] Use risers or boxes to add height.
- [ ] Keep fragile items away from the food table.

INTERACTIVE TOUCHES

- [ ] Advice cards and a box for the graduate to read later.
- [ ] A slideshow loop on a laptop or tablet.
- [ ] A photo booth corner with a banner and props.
- [ ] A map pin board for where the graduate is headed next.

PART 6

Rain and Weather Plan

- Decide your go or no-go for the tent by the Wednesday before the party and share it with your rental company.
- Ask your rental company about tent sidewalls, anchoring, and weights if the ground is hard or you cannot stake.
- Choose an indoor fallback such as a garage, basement, or community room and map where the food would go.
- Plan for a hot afternoon with shade, fans, water stations, and cold towels.
- Chicago can swing from cool and damp to hot in the same week in May and June, so keep a few umbrellas and light layers handy.
- Use heavy items, not light signs, to hold down tablecloths and banners on windy days.
- Keep your food table in the shade and use warming or cooling equipment that matches the weather.
- Tell guests where to park and where to go if the weather changes.
- Have a plan for wet chairs: towels and a way to dry them quickly.

PART 7

Questions to Ask Vendors

1. What is included in your open-house packages, and how many people does each portion size serve?
2. Do you provide serving staff, chafing dishes, and utensils, or do I supply them?
3. What is the minimum order, and how far out is the final headcount due?
4. When will rentals arrive and when will they be picked up?
5. Are tent anchoring options available for grass, patio, or driveway?
6. What is your policy if the weather forces a change within 48 hours?
7. Is there a cleaning or damage fee for rentals?
8. Can you deliver on a Saturday morning in May or June, and what is the delivery window?

PART 8

Party Worksheet

Fill this out and keep it on the fridge.

GRADUATE'S NAME AND SCHOOL

PARTY DATE AND TIME

VENUE OR ADDRESS

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

RAIN PLAN LOCATION

CATERER OR FOOD SOURCE AND PHONE

CAKE PICKUP TIME

RENTAL COMPANY AND DELIVERY WINDOW

TENT DECISION DEADLINE

HELPERS FOR SETUP AND CLEANUP

PARKING PLAN

TOTAL BUDGET

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.